HomeChef Sydney - Operational Playbook

What YOU Need to Do (Pre-Launch, Launch, and Post-Launch)

PRE-LAUNCH PHASE (Weeks 1-2)

Week 1: Foundation Setup

□ Business Basics (Day 1-2)

- [ ] **Register business name** (if needed - can operate as sole trader initially)
- [ ] **Set up business bank account** OR use PayPal Business
  - This is where customers will send payment
  - Keep separate from personal finances
- [ ] **Register domain name**: homechefsydney.com.au (or similar)
  - Use Crazy Domains, VentraIP, or Namecheap
  - Cost: ~$15-30/year
- [ ] **Set up business email**: hello@homechef.com.au
  - Option A: Google Workspace ($6/month) - professional
  - Option B: Free email forwarding to personal Gmail
- [ ] **Create WhatsApp Business account** with your phone number
  - This will be your main communication channel

□ Recruit Your First 2-3 Chefs (Day 3-5)

Where to find them:

- Your own network (friends who cook well)
- Local ethnic community Facebook groups
- Post in: "Indian Community Sydney", "Thai Food Lovers Sydney", etc.
- Religious/cultural centers (temples, mosques, churches)
- University international student groups

Your pitch to chefs:

```
"Hi! I'm starting a service connecting home cooks with customers
who want authentic home-cooked meals. Would you be interested in
cooking 5-10 meal sets per week? You'd earn $60-80 per week per
customer. I handle finding customers and collecting payment."
```

What to collect from each chef:

- Full name and contact (phone, email)
- Cuisine type
- 1 photo of them
- 5 sample dish names
- 3-5 photos of their food (can be phone photos)
- Preferred delivery days (Mon/Wed/Fri or Tue/Thu/Sat)
- How many customers they can handle (start small: 5-10)
- Their bank details for payment

First chef interview questions:

1. How long have you been cooking this cuisine?
2. Can you change your menu weekly?
3. Can you deliver within 5km of your home?
4. What would you charge per week for 5 meals?
5. Any food safety concerns? (allergies they can't accommodate, etc.)

Document everything in a spreadsheet:

- Chef name, phone, email, suburb
- Cuisine type
- Max weekly capacity
- Price they want to charge
- Bank details (for paying them)
- Status: Active / Onboarding / Inactive

□ Take/Collect Photos (Day 6-7)

- **Chef photos**: Use your phone, natural lighting, smiling
  - Don't need professional - authentic is better
- **Food photos**: Ask chefs to send 5 photos of their dishes
  - Accept phone photos for MVP
  - You can arrange professional photos later if business takes off

□ Prepare Your First Week's Menus

Work with each chef to finalize:

- This week's 5 dishes (with names that sound appetizing)
- Week dates (e.g., "Apr 1-5")

- Delivery schedule
- Final pricing

Week 2: Website Launch

□ Hand Off Website Build to AI Agent/Developer (Day 8-10)

- Provide them Document 1 (Technical Spec)
- Supply all chef content:
  - Names, bios, photos
  - Cuisine types
  - This week's menus
  - Prices and delivery days
- Review the built website before it goes live
- Test all forms yourself (submit test subscriptions)

□ Set Up Backend Systems (Day 11-12)

If using Softr + Airtable:

1. Create Airtable account (free tier is fine initially)
2. Developer will set up 4 tables:
   - Chefs
   - Weekly Menus
   - Customer Subscriptions
   - Chef Applications
3. Set up Airtable automations to email you when:
   - New customer subscribes
   - New chef applies
4. Test: Submit a fake subscription, make sure you get the email

If using Static HTML + Google Sheets:

1. Create Google account
2. Developer will set up Google Sheets with tabs:
   - Chefs
   - Menus
   - Subscriptions

    - Applications
3. Set up Google Apps Script to email you on form submissions
4. Test: Submit fake data, check it appears in sheets

☐ Prepare Email Templates (Day 12)

Save these in Gmail as canned responses OR in a Google Doc:

Template 1: Payment Instructions (send after customer subscribes)

```
Subject: Complete Your HomeChef Subscription - Payment Details

Hi [Customer Name],

Thanks for subscribing to Chef [Chef Name]'s home-cooked [Cuisine] meals!

PAYMENT DETAILS:
Amount: $[Price]
BSB: [Your BSB]
Account: [Your Account Number]
Account Name: [Your Business Name]
Reference: [CustomerName]-[StartDate]

Please pay within 24 hours to secure your spot.

Once payment is received, Chef [Chef Name] will contact you
to confirm your delivery times.

Your first delivery: [Day], [Date] between 5-8pm

Questions? Reply to this email or WhatsApp: [Your Number]

Cheers,
[Your Name]
HomeChef Sydney
```

Template 2: Payment Confirmation (send after they pay)

```
Subject: Payment Received - You're All Set!

Hi [Customer Name],

Payment received! You're all set for this week's meals.

Chef [Chef Name] will deliver to:
[Their Address]

Schedule:
[Day 1]: [Date] - [Time Window]
[Day 2]: [Date] - [Time Window]
[Day 3]: [Date] - [Time Window]

Chef [Chef Name]'s number: [Chef Phone]

We'll check in on Saturday to see how your first week went.

Enjoy!
[Your Name]
```

Template 3: Weekly Feedback Request (send Saturday)

```
Subject: How was your week with Chef [Chef Name]?

Hi [Customer Name],

Your first week with Chef [Chef Name] just wrapped up!

Quick 2-minute survey: [Google Forms Link]
- How were the meals? (1-5 stars)
- Would you subscribe again next week?
- Any feedback for the chef?

Want to continue next week? Just reply "YES" and you're locked in
for another week (same menu or Chef [Name] will send a new one).

Want to try a different chef? Check out next week's options:
[Website Link]

Thanks!
[Your Name]
```

Template 4: Chef Payment Notification (send Sunday after customer pays)

```
Subject: New Customer for Week of [Date]

Hi Chef [Name],

You have a new customer for next week!

Customer: [Name]
Phone: [Number]
Address: [Full Address]
Start Date: [Date]
Dietary Restrictions: [Text or "None"]

Delivery Schedule:
[Day 1]: [Date] between 5-8pm
[Day 2]: [Date] between 5-8pm
[Day 3]: [Date] between 5-8pm

Please confirm with the customer via WhatsApp 24 hours before
first delivery.

You'll be paid $[Amount] on [Next Sunday].

Thanks!
[Your Name]
```

☐ Create Google Forms for Feedback (Day 13)

Weekly Customer Feedback Form: Questions:

1. Your name (text)
2. Which chef did you order from? (dropdown)
3. Overall rating (1-5 scale)
4. How were the meals? (text)
5. Would you order from this chef again? (Yes/No)
6. Want to order for next week? (Yes - same chef / Yes - different chef / No)
7. Any issues with delivery or packaging? (text)

Save the shareable link - you'll send this every Saturday.

☐ Set Up Tracking Spreadsheet (Day 14)

Create a Master Operations Sheet in Google Sheets:

Tab 1: Weekly Revenue Tracker

Week Start	Customers	Total Revenue	Chef Payouts	Your Margin	Profit

Tab 2: Customer Pipeline

Customer Name	Email	Phone	Chef	Week 1 Status	Week 2 Status	Week 3 Status

- Status: Paid / Delivered / Churned / Cancelled

Tab 3: Delivery Schedule (Updated Weekly)

Day	Time	Customer	Address	Chef	Status

- Status: Scheduled / Delivered / Failed

Tab 4: Chef Performance

Chef Name	Week	Customers Served	Avg Rating	Delivery Success	Status

LAUNCH PHASE (Week 3)

Monday (Launch Day)

Morning

- [ ] **Final website check**: All links work, forms submit correctly
- [ ] **Post in 3-5 local Facebook groups**:

Sample post:

```
🍛 New: Home-Cooked Meal Subscriptions in [Your Suburbs]

Tired of cooking? Want healthier options than Uber Eats?

Get 5 authentic home-cooked meals delivered weekly from
local chefs in your neighborhood.

✓ Real home cooking (not restaurant food)
✓ $60-75 for 5 meals (cheaper than eating out)
✓ Support local cooks
✓ Cancel anytime

This week's chefs:
🇮🇳 Chef Priya - North Indian
🇹🇭 Chef Som - Thai
🇮🇹 Chef Maria - Italian

First 10 customers get 20% off!
[Link to your website]
```

Groups to post in:

- Your local suburb groups (e.g., "Newtown Community")
- Foodie groups ("Sydney Foodies", "Inner West Food Lovers")
- Buy/Sell/Swap groups (some allow local services)
- Parent groups (busy parents need easy meals)

Afternoon

☐ **Message 20-30 people directly** (WhatsApp/SMS/Facebook Messenger)

Sample message:

```
Hey! Quick question - would you pay $70 for 5 home-cooked
Indian/Thai/Italian meals delivered this week?

I'm launching a service connecting people with local home
chefs. First week 20% off ($56). No commitment after week 1.

Interested? [Link]
```

☐ **Email your contacts** (if you have a mailing list)
☐ **Post in your company Slack/Teams** (if allowed)
☐ **Physical flyers** (if time): Print 20 flyers, put them up at:

- Your office building
- Local gym
- Cafe bulletin boards
- University notice boards

Tuesday-Wednesday

- [ ] **Respond to inquiries within 2 hours**
  - Answer questions via WhatsApp, email, or Facebook comments
  - Common questions: "Can I choose dishes?" "Is it a long commitment?" "How does payment work?"
- [ ] **Send payment instructions immediately** when someone subscribes
  - Use your saved email template
  - Include clear bank details
  - Set deadline: "Pay within 24 hours to secure spot"
- [ ] **Track payments** in your spreadsheet
  - Mark "Paid" when bank transfer received
  - Follow up with non-payers after 24 hours: "Hey, just checking if you saw the payment details?"
- [ ] **Notify chefs** once customers pay
  - Use your saved template
  - Give them customer name, address, phone
  - Confirm delivery schedule

Thursday

- [ ] **Confirm all deliveries** are scheduled
  - Check your Delivery Schedule spreadsheet
  - Make sure each chef has confirmed with their customers
  - Follow up with any chef who hasn't confirmed yet
- [ ] **Handle any cancellations/changes**
  - If someone cancels, process refund immediately
  - Update your tracking sheets

Friday-Saturday (First Deliveries)

- [ ] **Monitor deliveries in real-time**
  - Ask chefs to WhatsApp you when each delivery is complete
  - Track in your spreadsheet: Delivered / Failed
  - Be ready to handle issues (chef running late, wrong address, etc.)

- [ ] **Handle delivery problems immediately**:
  - If chef can't deliver → YOU deliver (or issue refund)
  - If customer not home → coordinate reschedule
  - If food quality issue → offer immediate refund

Saturday Evening

- [ ] **Send feedback forms** to all customers
  - Use your Google Form link
  - Send via email AND WhatsApp for better response rate
  - "How was your first week? Quick 2-min survey: [link]"

Sunday

- [ ] **Analyze Week 1 results**
  - How many customers paid?
  - How many deliveries succeeded?
  - What was the average rating?
  - How many want to order again?
- [ ] **Pay your chefs**
  - Calculate: (Customer paid $75, chef gets $60, you keep $15)
  - Bank transfer to each chef
  - Send confirmation: "Payment sent for this week. See you next week?"
- [ ] **Plan Week 2**
  - Ask chefs for next week's menu
  - Ask customers if they want to continue
  - Update website with new menus

POST-LAUNCH OPERATIONS (Ongoing Weekly Routine)

Your Weekly Schedule

SUNDAY (Menu Planning)

Time needed: 1-2 hours

- [ ] **Get next week's menus from chefs** (via WhatsApp)
  - Chef Priya: What are you cooking Apr 8-12?
  - Chef Som: What's your menu for next week?
  - Deadline: Sunday 6pm

- [ ] **Update website with new menus**
  - If using Softr: Update Airtable "Weekly Menus" table
  - If static HTML: Send menu updates to developer (or update yourself if you know how)
- [ ] **Pay chefs from previous week**
  - Check your tracking sheet for how many customers they served
  - Calculate: [Number of customers] × [Their cut per customer]
  - Bank transfer to each chef
  - Send receipt via email
- [ ] **Plan week ahead**
  - Review how many customers continuing vs. churning
  - If capacity available, plan marketing push for Monday

MONDAY (Customer Acquisition)

Time needed: 2-3 hours

- [ ] **Marketing push** (if you have capacity for more customers)
  - Post in 2-3 Facebook groups
  - Message 10 new people
  - Email anyone on waitlist
- [ ] **Reactivation campaign** (for churned customers)
  - Email customers who didn't order this week:

```
Hey [Name], we missed you this week!
Try a different chef? This week we have:
- Chef Som's Thai menu
- Chef Maria's Italian menu
First meal free if you order by Tuesday. [Link]
```

- [ ] **Check for new subscriptions**
  - Monitor Airtable/Google Sheets
  - Respond to new submissions within 2 hours
  - Send payment instructions

TUESDAY (Payment Collection)

Time needed: 1 hour

- [ ] **Follow up on unpaid subscriptions**

- Check who submitted forms but hasn't paid
- Send reminder: "Hi! Just checking if you saw the payment details? Let me know if you have any questions."

☐ **Confirm payments received**

- Check bank account for transfers
- Mark "Paid" in spreadsheet
- Send payment confirmation email to customer
- Notify chef of new customer (with delivery details)

WEDNESDAY (Delivery Prep)

Time needed: 30 minutes

☐ **Confirm all chefs are ready**

- WhatsApp each chef: "All set for deliveries this week?"
- Make sure they have all customer addresses
- Confirm delivery schedule

☐ **Handle any last-minute issues**

- Chef sick? Offer refund or find replacement
- Customer changed address? Update chef
- Dietary restriction added? Notify chef

THURSDAY-SATURDAY (Delivery Week)

Time needed: 1-2 hours/day

☐ **Monitor deliveries**

- Ask chefs to confirm after each delivery
- Update "Delivery Schedule" spreadsheet in real-time
- Be available on WhatsApp for issues

☐ **Handle problems immediately**

- Missed delivery? Arrange makeup or refund
- Food quality complaint? Issue refund, address with chef
- Customer not home? Help reschedule

☐ **Proactive check-ins**

- Thursday evening: "Hi [Customer], Chef [Name] will deliver tomorrow between 5-8pm. Excited for your meals!"

SATURDAY EVENING (Feedback Collection)

Time needed: 30 minutes

- [ ] **Send feedback forms** to all customers
  - Use your Google Form link
  - Track who responds
  - Follow up Sunday morning if no response
- [ ] **Review feedback as it comes in**
  - Good ratings (4-5 stars): Ask if they want to order next week
  - Bad ratings (1-3 stars): Call them immediately to understand what went wrong

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SUNDAY (Analysis & Planning)

Time needed: 2 hours

- [ ] **Weekly metrics review**
  - Total customers this week
  - Revenue (total payments received)
  - Chef payouts
  - Your profit margin
  - Retention rate (% of customers who ordered again)
  - Average rating per chef
- [ ] **Update chef performance tracker**
  - Which chefs had delivery issues?
  - Which chefs had highest ratings?
  - Any chefs consistently below 4.0 stars? (flag for offboarding)
- [ ] **Calculate payouts and transfer**
  - Pay each chef their earnings
  - Update payment status in spreadsheet
- [ ] **Plan next week's growth**
  - If at capacity: Don't market, focus on retention
  - If under capacity: Plan marketing for Monday
  - If chefs are maxed out: Recruit new chefs

CUSTOMER ACQUISITION TACTICS (Ongoing)

Weekly Marketing Activities

Low Effort (30 min/week):

- Post in 2-3 Facebook groups (rotate which groups)
- Update Instagram story with this week's menus (if you create account)
- Email anyone on waitlist

Medium Effort (1-2 hours/week):

- Message 10-20 new people in your network
- Put up 5-10 flyers in local cafes/gyms
- Reach out to 1-2 companies about corporate lunch service

High Effort (3+ hours/week):

- Run small Facebook ads ($50/week budget)
- Attend local events, hand out flyers
- Partner with gyms/yoga studios (leave flyers, offer commission)
- Start Instagram account, post food photos daily

Referral Program (Launch Week 4)

Once you have 10+ happy customers:

Simple referral system:

- "Refer a friend, you both get $10 off next week"
- Track manually in spreadsheet
- Apply discount at payment time

Email to existing customers:

```
Love your meals? Invite a friend!

Share this link: [yoursite.com]
When they order, you both get $10 off.

Your personal referral code: [NAME10]
```

Content Marketing (If you have time)

Instagram (optional but recommended):

- Post chef stories (behind-the-scenes cooking)
- Post customer testimonials
- Post weekly menus with food photos
- Use hashtags: #sydneyfood #homecooking #innerwesthttps://

Local PR (Month 2-3):

- Email local food bloggers
- Pitch story to: Time Out Sydney, Concrete Playground, Daily Telegraph
- Angle: "Supporting immigrant home cooks in Sydney"

HANDLING COMMON ISSUES

Customer Issues

Issue: "I didn't like the food" Response:

1. Apologize immediately
2. Offer full refund, no questions asked (for first week)
3. Suggest trying a different chef next week (50% off)
4. Document feedback for the chef

Issue: "Chef was late / missed delivery" Response:

1. Apologize
2. Immediate refund OR free next week
3. Talk to chef about what happened
4. If chef misses 2 deliveries → offboard them

Issue: "Can I cancel?" Response:

1. "Of course! No problem at all."
2. Process refund if they already paid for next week
3. Mark them as "Churned" in spreadsheet
4. Ask: "Can I ask why? We're always trying to improve."

Issue: "Food made me sick" Response:

1. Take this VERY seriously
2. Full refund immediately
3. Get details: What did they eat? When? Symptoms?

4. Talk to chef immediately
5. If multiple customers report same issue → pause that chef
6. Document everything (potential liability)

Chef Issues

Issue: Chef can't deliver this week (sick, emergency) Response:

1. Contact their customers immediately
2. Options:
    - Offer to deliver yourself (if you can cook or buy restaurant food)
    - Switch them to a different chef for this week
    - Full refund
3. Don't penalize chef for one-off emergencies
4. If happens repeatedly → offboard

Issue: Chef's ratings dropping (below 4.0) Response:

1. Call them (don't just message)
2. Share specific feedback from customers
3. Ask: "What's happening? How can we help?"
4. Give them 2 weeks to improve
5. If ratings don't improve → offboard

Offboarding a chef:

```
Hi [Chef Name],

Thanks for being part of HomeChef. Unfortunately, we've
had some feedback about [specific issues] and we think
it's best to pause for now.

I'll pay you for any outstanding deliveries. Let me know
if you'd like to try again in a few months.

All the best,
[Your Name]
```

Issue: Chef wants to raise prices Response:

1. Understand why (ingredients cost more? More work than expected?)
2. Negotiate: Can you both split the increase?

3. If reasonable, allow it - but give customers notice
4. Email customers: "Chef [Name] is increasing to $X next week. Still want to continue?"

FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT

Pricing Structure (Your Margins)

Example:

- Customer pays: $75/week
- Chef receives: $60/week (80%)
- You keep: $15/week (20%)

With 10 customers:

- Revenue: $750/week
- Chef payouts: $600/week
- Your margin: $150/week
- Platform costs: ~$20/week (Softr + Airtable)
- **Net profit: ~$130/week ($520/month)**

Tracking Money

Every Sunday, calculate:

1. **Revenue this week**: Total customer payments received
2. **Chef payouts**: Sum of all amounts owed to chefs
3. **Platform costs**: Softr, Airtable, domain, etc.
4. **Profit**: Revenue - Payouts - Costs
5. **Retention rate**: (Customers who ordered again) / (Last week's customers)

Keep a running Cash Flow Sheet:

Week	Revenue	Payouts	Costs	Profit	Cumulative

When to Reinvest

Don't spend on fancy features until:

- You have 20+ customers per week
- 70%+ retention rate (customers ordering week 2)
- Profitable for 3+ weeks in a row

Then consider:

- Paying for Stripe integration ($300-500) so you don't manually collect payments
- Better food photography ($200-300 one-time)
- Facebook ads ($100-200/month)

SCALING DECISIONS

When to Hire Help

Hire a part-time VA (Virtual Assistant) when:

- You're spending 15+ hours/week on operations
- You have 30+ customers
- You're profitable

What to delegate:

- Sending payment instructions
- Following up on unpaid invoices
- Confirming deliveries with chefs
- Sending feedback forms

Cost: $10-15/hour for 5-10 hours/week

When to Build Proper Tech

Only after:

- 50+ customers per week
- $2,000+ profit per month
- 6+ months of consistent operation
- Clear retention data showing which features would help

Then consider hiring a developer to build:

- Automated payment processing (Stripe)
- Chef self-service dashboard
- Customer accounts with order history
- Basic recommendation system

Cost: $10,000-20,000 for proper custom platform

SUCCESS METRICS TO TRACK

Week 1 Goals

- [ ] 5-10 paying customers
- [ ] 90%+ successful deliveries
- [ ] 1+ customer wanting to order Week 2

Month 1 Goals

- [ ] 15-20 active customers
- [ ] 60%+ retention rate (week-to-week)
- [ ] 4.5+ average rating
- [ ] Break-even on costs

Month 3 Goals

- [ ] 30-40 active customers
- [ ] 70%+ retention rate
- [ ] $500+ profit per month
- [ ] 5+ active chefs
- [ ] Proven playbook for recruiting chefs and customers

Month 6 Decision Point

If hitting goals:

- Invest in proper platform
- Hire part-time help
- Expand to second suburb or city

If NOT hitting goals:

- Analyze: Is it customer acquisition or retention?
- Pivot pricing, chef selection, or target customer
- Or gracefully shut down and return to concept validation

RED FLAGS (When to Pivot or Quit)

Stop and reassess if:

❌ **Retention below 40% after Month 2**

- Customers trying once but not reordering
- Problem: Either food quality or value proposition

❌ **Can't recruit reliable chefs**

- Chefs keep missing deliveries
- Chefs quitting after 1-2 weeks
- Problem: Chef economics don't work or too much hassle for them

❌ **Spending 20+ hours/week for $200/month profit**

- Not scalable, not sustainable
- Better to get a part-time job

❌ **Food safety incident**

- Customer gets sick
- Health department investigation
- Liability you can't handle

❌ **Burnout**

- You hate doing this
- It's affecting your day job or mental health
- Not worth it

If you see these, options:

1. **Pivot**: Change pricing, target customer, or chef model
2. **Pause**: Take 2 weeks off to reassess
3. **Sell**: Find someone to take over operations
4. **Shut down**: Refund customers, pay chefs, close shop

EMERGENCY CONTACTS & RESOURCES

Keep These Handy

Your Chefs' Contacts:

- Chef 1: [Name, Phone, Email]
- Chef 2: [Name, Phone, Email]
- Chef 3: [Name, Phone, Email]

Business Services:

- Domain registrar: [Login details]
- Bank account: [Account number]
- Airtable/Google Sheets: [Login details]
- Website host: [Login details]

Emergency Backup Plans:

- If chef cancels last minute: [Backup chef? Your own cooking? Refund?]
- If you're sick/unavailable: [Who can handle operations?]
- If website goes down: [Developer contact, hosting support]

Useful Resources

Food Safety (if needed later):

- NSW Food Authority: foodauthority.nsw.gov.au
- Food Safety Supervisor course: 1-day online course

Insurance (if scaling up):

- Public Liability Insurance: Compare on iSelect or similar
- Cost: ~$300-500/year

Legal:

- Terms of Service template: lawpath.com.au
- Privacy Policy generator: termsfeed.com

FINAL REMINDERS

Your North Star Metrics

1. **Customer retention**: % who order week 2, 3, 4
2. **Chef reliability**: % successful deliveries
3. **Profitability**: Revenue - costs = positive?

Your Time Budget

- **Weeks 1-4**: 10-15 hours/week (setup + launch)
- **Weeks 5-8**: 5-10 hours/week (if running smoothly)

- **Month 3+**: 5 hours/week (if mostly automated)

If it's more than 15 hours/week after Month 2, something's broken.

Remember

- This is an MVP - expect things to break
- Your goal is to learn, not to be perfect
- Talk to customers constantly (they'll tell you what to fix)
- Don't build features until you prove people want this
- Prioritize reliability over growth (10 happy customers > 30 unhappy ones)

You're not building a tech company yet. You're validating a service business.

Once you prove people want this (60%+ retention, profitable, 30+ customers), THEN you build the real platform.

END OF OPERATIONAL PLAYBOOK